

Foreign Gifts Findings Report: Foreign Funding Strategies for UVA

Executive Summary: What are your main findings and recommendations, in a single paragraph?

From my analysis, I found that UVA currently has a solid foundation of diverse foreign giving but has failed to tap into high-value donors shared by both its Virginia peers and the market at large. As compared to its Virginia peers, UVA sits right in the middle of total gift sum received, despite being ranked substantially higher at both the state and national level than the two Virginia institutions who receive more (VCU and GMU). By investigating high-value, consistent donors at both Virginia-level and market-level, I identified a strong opportunity for UVA to pursue high-value Saudi Arabian funding (The Saudi Arabian Cultural Mission), as well as an opportunity to leverage an existing partnership (AstraZeneca). Due to UVA's diverse and consistent funding record, UVA has the unique potential to capitalize on new *and* previous giftor relationships, as highlighted in my report below.

Analyses Summary: Summarize the results of your initial analyses of overall giving and giving to UVA (1-3 paragraphs).

The initial analysis of the Foreign Gifts dataset provided a baseline for understanding significant trends in the data. For example, we can easily identify which countries give the most money (e.g., Qatar, England, China, and Saudi Arabia have all given over \$1 billion in total gifts) or the most gifts by count, as well as the top universities who receive these funds (e.g., Carnegie Mellon University and Cornell University). We can also summarize at the university-level how the distribution of funds differs (e.g., the mean of total gift sum per school is around \$52 million, whereas the median is closer to \$6.5 million) and see that there's a diverse scope of foreign giving across US universities. Finally, one of the final initial analysis tasks was to look at the top individual giftors (i.e., the companies, institutions, government agencies, etc. who are the actual donors) rather than at the countries broadly, revealing that our initial country-level analyses may not be the most useful. In the same vein, there are so many universities in this dataset with varying levels of gift transactions (some schools have only received one gift), that a broad snapshot of giving doesn't provide much meaning for how much funding a school could aim to receive.

With this understanding in mind, my analysis of UVA compared to its peer institutions heavily focused on investigating every variable available to me, including date, institution type, and gift amount. I was able to recontextualize the \$52 million average gift

sum and \$6.5 median gift sum for the entire market into a Virginia-level mean of \$38,392,997 and a Virginia-level median of \$22,189,238. UVA actually falls in the middle of total gift sums received by a Virginia school (\$22,189,238) and is substantially outstepped by Virginia Commonwealth University in both total sum (VCU's \$89 million vs. UVA's \$22,000,000) and average gift size (VCU's \$775,000 to UVA's \$225,000). VCU also has gifts from more countries (23 vs. 15) and a higher gift count overall (115 vs. 98). In addition, UVA is also outstepped by GMU as well in total gift sum (\$65 million) and average gift size (\$1.7 million).

As I talk about in more detail below, my analysis then revealed that the majority of VCU and GMU's gift money each came from one country (Qatar and Saudi Arabia, respectively), whereas UVA's foreign giving was more diverse/consistent across many different countries. These state-level trends (high-value donors vs. consistent donors) thus informed my quantitative strategy for finding giftors for UVA to target, specifically exploring consistency/diverse spending habits over time (described below).

Proposed Strategy: Describe a strategy for finding new potential sources of money for UVA. What countries or institutions should UVA target, and why? (1-3 paragraphs)

Through the *Initial Analysis* portion of the lab, we identified surface-level trends in the dataset to better equip us for deeper analysis for UVA. For example, our initial analysis helped reveal top countries of giftors (by gift count and gift size), the distribution of gifts across US universities, and trends in gift size/amount. At first glance, this initial exploration seems to provide helpful, straightforward answers to which countries give the most money (e.g., Qatar, England, or China) and therefore who UVA could target, but the reality is that country-level analysis ignores the true donors in the dataset — the actual individual giftors/institutions, many of whom are not affiliated with the foreign government at all (e.g., private companies/foundations). Even if I were to break down country-level gifts for only UVA's peers, ignoring the context behind these donations does not provide very helpful information for funding strategies (e.g., broadly targeting "England" is very different from targeting GlaxoSmithKline, the UK-based pharmaceutical company). Therefore, the results of the initial analysis are not sufficient for truly understanding the scope/trends in foreign gift giving, and for my UVA analysis, I probed deeper by focusing on gifts over time, gift count by institution (not only country), and shared donors between UVA, UVA's peers, and the market at large.

First, in order to better understand the scope of the dataset, I reformatted and summarized the *Foreign Gift Received Date* column. This investigation revealed that the Foreign Gifts dataset is a **snapshot of gift transactions from 2014-2020** and thus should be considered in this context. For example, the data we're working with are pre-Covid

numbers, so any strategies we propose from this data inherently won't include how the pandemic may have caused changes in foreign relationships/opportunities (or how geopolitical relationships at large have shifted since 2020). Despite a more limited timeframe of data than I anticipated, I still decided to use date as an important measure of gift trends, as it provided nuance beyond total gift count to countries' spending attitudes. For example, as I started my UVA analysis, I was able to pinpoint top giftors for UVA not only by count but also by consistency over the years, which revealed long-term giving relationships with Bangladesh, Sweden, and England. As an example, Bangladesh has given the most money to UVA overall (\$4,228,589) through 10 total gifts spanning five years (2014-2019), whereas Israel has only given UVA \$623,655 over two years (2014, 2016), despite giving 12 total gifts. By investigating the date variable, we can see which countries have a consistent giving relationship with UVA over time, which gives UVA the insight to potentially prioritize these partnerships in the future.

Next, I investigated country-level and institution-level giving between UVA and its peer schools. For my analysis, I decided to only include Virginia schools (rather than reaching into North Carolina for schools like UNC), because the subset of Virginia schools in the dataset provided meaningful comparisons in size, academic rigor, and research focus (e.g., all were larger public universities with mid-to-high academic standards). My initial analysis of UVA and other Virginia schools first suggested that UVA falls behind its peer institutions in total gift sum and average gift size (especially as compared to Virginia Commonwealth University (VCU), which has received \$89 million in total gifts, with an average gift size of \$775,000, compared to UVA's \$22 million total and \$225,000 average). However, after looking at the country-level data, I noticed that the majority of VCU's (and GMU's) funds came from middle eastern countries like Qatar and Saudi Arabia, and if removed, would knock their totals and average gift sizes to below or equivalent to UVA. Additionally, by removing large spenders, we can see that UVA otherwise has most diverse AND consistent gift flow of all Virginia schools, suggesting a sustainability that other schools might lack. With this full picture, trying to target the high-value donors shared by other Virginia schools would be a smart strategy for UVA, as they've already established a strong, consistent foundation of gift flow. With this strategy in mind, I then investigated both the country-level and institution-level of high giftors at other Virginia universities currently not shared by UVA. I discovered that the Royal Embassy of Saudi Arabia, specifically the Saudi Arabian Cultural Mission, have given millions of dollars to both GMU and W&M. Notably, GMU's donor is only listed as "The Royal Embassy of Saudi Arabia," but through additional research I uncovered that GMU's Saudi funding was specifically "a contractual arrangement with the Saudi Arabian Cultural Mission to collect tuition and fees for students who receive Saudi government scholarships" (per an [Inside Higher Ed article](#)),

and therefore fell under SACM like W&M. Additionally, my research further revealed that the SACM headquarters is located in northern Virginia, which makes it an even more accessible target for UVA. Finally, this part of the analysis revealed that UVA and VCU have both received gifts from the British and Swedish company AstraZeneca, with UVA's gift listing Sweden as the country of origin and VCU's listing England as the country of origin. More investigation is warranted into leveraging this connection (e.g., Does each country handle different funding sources/initiatives? If so, is there an opportunity for UVA to enter into the British side of AstraZeneca's funding?).

Finally, with this institution-level framework in mind, I then expanded my analysis back to the market at large to discover institutions who give consistently to a high number of unique schools, as well as if other non-UVA Virginia schools have connections to these top donors. To decide which country's institutions to focus on, I filtered countries by those who gave gifts to the highest number of unique schools and then filtered further for those who gave *consistently* (i.e., more than two years) to the most schools. From this list, I chose the top five (i.e., China, Saudi Arabia, Japan, England, and Canada) and gave lists of every individual donor in those countries to ChatGPT to help me create a mapping function for standardization. A more thorough cleaning/standardization would definitely be possible but doing it this way gave me the ability to spot meaningful trends without sacrificing too much time. After cleaning up giftor names, I investigated the top individual donors by gift count per most schools, and the Saudi Arabian Cultural Mission was revealed to be the top giftor in the market at large, further solidifying them as a top target for UVA. AstraZeneca also made the top ten as well, solidifying them a previous UVA giftor that may deserve future attention (with potential opportunities to reach both Swedish and British funding). Pursuing funding from giftors who've given to Virginia universities might create weird politics, but by expanding my analysis to the market-level and identifying giftors who consistently give to many different non-Virginia schools (in addition to a Virginia school), it instead provides a framework for pursuing potential donors that match UVA's profile without compromising potential relationships.

Conclusion: Conclude with a summary of UVA's prospects for increasing foreign giving. (1 paragraph).

Among Virginia schools, UVA boasts the most sustainable foreign gifts model, as it receives consistent, diverse gifts from many different countries. Additionally, UVA has three countries who have given consistent, large donations over at least four years (i.e., Bangladesh, Sweden, and England), suggesting easy avenues for future partnerships with these countries. Because UVA already has this strong foundation, tapping into high-value donors should definitely be considered a priority, and the most accessible (and wealthiest)

option would be the Saudi Arabian Cultural Mission (SACM). Not only have two other Virginia schools (GMU and W&M) received millions in gifts, but SACM is the top donor in the entire dataset for giving to the most distinct schools, further reflecting a potentially easier path for securing funding. Finally, the US headquarters for SACM are literally in Northern Virginia, only two hours away from UVA, allowing UVA to leverage in-person visits/communication to establish a more meaningful relationship.

Finally, another top donor that gives to the highest number of distinct schools is AstraZeneca (a British/Swedish company), which UVA* has received gifts from in the past (with Sweden listed as the host country). VCU also has a history with AstraZeneca, but VCU's transactions list "England" as the host country, so the distinction between Swedish vs. British funding (if it exists) could be worth leveraging in the future (as well as future partnerships in general). Pursuing AstraZeneca further is a unique opportunity to UVA, as the company consistently gives to schools across the entire market (top ten) and already has an existing relationship with UVA.

****Note: As I was finishing this report, I decided to do more research on AstraZeneca, and I saw that UVA officially entered a research partnership with AstraZeneca this year (tied to a 4.5-billion-dollar project), so I wanted to clarify that I did NOT know this when I originally chose AstraZeneca as a potential target! So, I am pleasantly surprised by the supposed accuracy of my choice.***